

was frenetic," he said. "All the orders were coming in on one side." (Mr. Epstein meant that everyone wanted to bet on the market's going down all at once.) "I never saw anything like it."

William Hayes, the analyst who took me to lunch at the New York Stock Exchange, spent the day in the offices of his specialist firm and took the drop calmly: "I certainly didn't expect 508 points. A lot of it had to do with the instantaneous network we've created, all over the world. Remember, some real buyers came in that day, too."

Jeff Zaret, one of the young traders at the Chicago Mercantile Exchange struggling to make a living, had moved upstairs and allied himself with the trading department of a large Japanese bank. "There are great possibilities in the global markets," he had said. On the day of the debacle, he revisited his old haunt, the S&P trading pit, where he was happy not to be working: "I saw haggard faces. A lot of guys were elated, true, but then again there were more long faces. Mostly, guys looked confounded."

Donald Trump, the New York tycoon whose *faux* takeover of Bally I'd mistaken for genuine inside information, announced to the world that he'd been out of the stock market for months—probably even at the time I'd invested in his alleged machinations. Other corporate raiders, including Boone Pickens and Sir James Goldsmith, volunteered that they, too, had gotten out of the stock market with profits intact. Many of the prominent billionaires, whom average investors adopted as inspirations in the headlong greedy rush to riches, had apparently closed out their positions—leaving them with all the money, and the rest of us punished for the greed.

Al Frank, genial editor of the *Prudent Speculator*, had been on a diet and had lost a lot of weight, which seemed to parallel the decline in the heft of his portfolio. On his weekly FNN interview slot, he looked slimmer and also more somber than I'd ever seen him, but still he had a sense of humor. What had he learned about this market? the newscaster asked. "Learned about how to get margin calls," he said.

Robert Prechter Jr., the Elliott wave theorist who carries on the entirely illogical but apparently effective zigzag method of forecasting, advised his clients to get out of the market at the high